



Celebrating modern Laos

The victory of the communist Pathet Lao forces in 1975 led to the establishment of a one-party state, which celebrated its achievements through posters and other forms of propaganda.

Genocidal retribution

Some resistance continued against the Pathet Lao regime, which announced that it would hunt down “American collaborators.” The main targets of this campaign were the Hmong people. The new government set out to punish the Hmong who had fought with or supported General Vang Pao, a Hmong leader who had collaborated with the United States in fighting the communists in Laos. This quest for revenge expanded into a genocidal campaign aimed at eradicating the Hmong people and their culture. As many as 200,000 Hmong fled into Thailand and a number of Hmong fighters took refuge in mountains. In later negotiations Laos agreed to repatriate 60,000 Lao refugees living in Thailand, including several thousand Hmong people. Fearing violence against them, the Hmong resisted return—their concern was well founded. The communist government bombed their villages with poison gas and allowed atrocities against those who returned.

500 The number of US fliers shot down over Laos.

14 The number of US POWs repatriated from Laos.